

“Music, The Soundtrack of our Lives”

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As time passes, we lose touch with the past. The temporal distance throughout the passages of many years creates a gap between ourselves. We become different people as we age; our bodies change, our minds develop, our identities evolve. There are mechanisms that allow us to feel a sense of continuity—to revisit all the things we experienced—as we face these changes: photos capture instances of our lives, videos record events we lived through, journals hold the thoughts we had, and memory stores all these things within our minds. However, these modes of recalling the past are flawed, subject to distortion. As time passes, these modes of recalling the past also become distanced from ourselves; they can only rekindle impressions of the events of our life stories. When we look back at the past through these things—which themselves are relics of the past—we are spectators rather than participants of our past. There is no way to truly return to the past in this way. No matter how much we believe we can hold onto the past, the past is gone, washed away unforgivingly by time.

Music provides us with a unique way to interact with our past. Music is timeless. Unlike ourselves, music is unchanged; no matter how much time passes, the same arrangement of notes is present in the songs we listen to. Amidst all the changes we experience, music serves as a constant in our lives, acting as a bridge to our past. Listening to music can allow us to stay in touch with the past by acting as a trigger for memories. Because it can elicit very intense emotions, music is deeply connected to who we are (Hodges and Wilkins 44). Music's strong connection to emotion makes it applicable in retaining our past for emotion can provoke memories vividly. Sound, more generally, is an integral part of being human, as it is one of our five senses; we constantly absorb the sound around us. In this way, music is also integral to ourselves for it can serve as a soundtrack to the things we experience over time. The intense emotions associated with music can elicit memories vividly. The act of listening to the music we

value allows us to re-experience the emotions we felt in the past and revisit the memories associated with the music. However, as the sharpness of these music-induced memories fades away like with the other modes of memory retention, we can continue to interact with them to create new meanings and understandings of them and due to the unchanging nature of music—by continually listening to the same music associated with faltering memories, we can preserve our relationship with them, though with a new understanding. Thus, listening to music allows us to keep in touch with our pasts through its static revisiting through intense emotions and dynamic revising through its perpetuity.

The relationships we have with the music we listen to help us better understand ourselves. Unlike the fallibility of memory, which is subject to distortion as time passes, music remains unchanged; it serves as an untouched artifact of the past that we can continually revisit. The strong emotions attached to the music we listen to allow for the vivid recollection of past experiences. In a survey conducted by Terrence Hays and Victor Minichiello of the University of New England, participants of old age asked about the meaning of music in their lives revealed the importance of listening to music in understanding themselves; certain selections of music were able to elicit strong memories associated with them (Hays and Minichiello 437). They recalled the people, setting, and experiences associated with the music. One participant described music as a “direct link back to your whole life” where “Strong memories of sensations, emotions, people and places . . . they are still very vivid” (Hays and Minichiello 441). Whereas telling stories is one way of remembering the past, listening to music is another mode of rekindling our memories of our past experiences; when listening to music, there are no words that describe what happened. Rather, we simply relive the impressions and emotions we felt at that moment in the past while we relisten to the music. It is in this way music helps with the

retention of our past—by providing us with the opportunity to vividly experience the emotions again.

Music plays a more direct role in preserving our past through its ability to evoke autobiographical memories. A research article in *PLOS One* conducted by Salakka et al. on the relationship between music and evoked memories revealed the strong correlation between music-evoked emotions and music-evoked memories (Salakka et al. 2). Music-evoked autobiographical memories were found to be stronger than consciously recalled memories (Salakka et al. 3). The emotions evoked by music become more intense as the music becomes more familiar through repetition. Thus, as we listen to certain songs more frequently, we create stronger connections with them; they become landmarks of moments in our lives. In a paper published in *Taylor & Francis*, Belfi et al. it was found that autobiographical memories evoked by memories were more vivid than those evoked by looking at faces (Belfi et al. 986). These memories contained more internal and perceptual details than those elicited by cues other than music. In this way, the study demonstrated the possibility of music's ability to evoke emotions comparable to those experienced in the past; this re-experiencing allows for the vivid recollection of the past (Belfi et al. 985).

The strength of music's ability to preserve our memories is further demonstrated by its application in cognitive rehabilitation. Research has shown the possibility of musical memories remaining longer than nonmusical memories for individuals with neurological memory disorders (Thaut 282). The strong link between music and emotion makes it possible to rekindle memories more easily. Neuroimaging shows that the areas of the brain involved in emotion, music, and autobiographical memory are relatively untouched in Alzheimer's, thus possibly illustrating its ability to allow patients with dementia to remember the forgotten (Salakka et al. 3). Even as we

age, when our memory falters and our cognitive abilities begin to deteriorate, music provides a way to stay in touch with our past—it is unweathered by the storm of time.

Listening to music can transport us back in time. American jazz singer Tony Bennett, diagnosed with Alzheimer's, struggled to recognize the people he was with and to identify the significance of photos from his life. But even at the age of 94, battling Alzheimer's, as he performed his final acts, Tony Bennett was transformed back into the singer he was as he performed on stage, flawlessly playing the music he had been so many years ago (60 Minutes). Similarly, Marta C. Gonzalez, a former ballerina diagnosed with Alzheimer's, was transformed as she listened to *Swan Lake*, a piece she performed 50 years before. Researchers from the Spanish organization, "Music to Awaken," described the experience as if "part of her mind traveled to another moment of her life" (Brut America). Gonzalez said listening to the piece made her emotional. Music is rooted in emotion; listening to the music hold dear makes us feel these emotions, makes us feel alive, makes us relive the memories associated with those emotions.

In this way, music acts as a soundtrack to our lives. The sounds we hear when we listen to songs are exactly the same as the sounds we listened to when we listened to them in the past. Thus, there is the possibility of associating certain songs with particular memories or stages of our lives. A series of responses from listeners to the *Dutch Top 2000* radio event reveals this association between music and certain events in our lives. Many participants in the event shared the stories they had attached to certain songs (Karin Bijsterveld and José van Dijck 109). For them, listening to these specified songs allowed them to revisit a certain moment and to experience the emotions. One participant had the following relationship with the song "With Or Without You," by U2:

My father died suddenly in November 1986. That night we all stayed awake. I isolated myself from my family by putting on the headphones and listening to this song. The intense sorrow I felt that night was expressed in Bono's intense screams. I will never forget this experience, and each time I hear this song I get tears in my eyes.

Just as music scores provide a soundtrack to certain scenes in a film, the songs we value can serve as records for certain experiences and memories. The participant's selection of words illustrates the power of music in our lives. The phrase "the intense sorrow... was expressed in Bono's intense screams" demonstrates how the song was the means through which the respondent was able to feel the emotions they were experiencing; music was the respondent's coping mechanism. Furthermore, the phrase "I will never forget this experience, and each time I hear this song" portrays how the song was able to capture the memory and emotions from the respondent's father's death. Music was able to encapsulate this important event in the participant's life, which is now available to be revisited by listening to the song; in this way, the event continues to live on through the lyrics and the sounds from the song.

However, it can be argued that music's ability to connect us to the past is not unique, that we can re-experience certain events through any form of media and art. Though it is true that people reread books and rewatch movies to elicit nostalgia, the accessibility of music makes its kindling of the past special. The act of reading or watching a movie requires a significant amount of attention to consume. The amount of effort needed to engage with these compositions makes the experience of engaging with them more about the work itself rather than the emotions and memories attached to them. In this way, music's role as the soundtrack, rather than as the main storyline, uniquely allows for the revisiting of our pasts. When we nostalgically listen to music, we long for the memories associated with them, not the music itself. Music is the means through which we can re-experience our memories, not the events that we relive.

While music's ability to rekindle emotions and memories from the past vividly is apparent, the act of listening to the same music is inescapably subject to the same change as when recalling memories from the past—that is, at some point in time, the distance between ourselves from our pasts become too large so that even the music-induced emotions and memories cannot bridge them together. When this happens, we cannot entirely re-experience the past as we are now different people; though we can listen to the same songs we did in the past, we listen to them in another way. Just as memories no longer represent what actually happened when we look back to them as different people, because we listen to these same songs with evolved identities, we listen to them differently; their meanings are altered and thus cannot evoke the same exact emotions. Though the mode of holding onto the past through music is subject to the same alterations as with memory, because the music itself is unchanged (whereas memories themselves alter over time), we can continue engaging with the same music. Thus, music allows for the dynamic storytelling of our lives; through music, we can continue to engage with those stories that would have otherwise been lost.

In this way, the meanings of certain songs to us change as we age. Lei Ouyang Bryant, an Associate Professor of Music at Skidmore College, explored music and nostalgia across different generations during the Cultural Revolution. Bryant analyzed the intensity of nostalgia experienced by individuals regarding the Cultural Revolutionary songs in the collective memories of the *New Songs of the Battlefield*, an anthology of songs published to propagate the Cultural Revolution ideologies (151). She also noticed that “the particular emotions and memories associated with the songs are, in fact, directly correlated to specific generations” (166). The meaning of the music we listen to changes as we age. Though the people during the Cultural Revolution all listened to the same songs, because they were at different stages of their lives,

they had distinct relationships with the same music. Though time alters our understanding of music just like it does with our memories, the unchanging nature of the songs themselves allows our relationship with music to grow for we can continually engage with it.

This possibility of change allows music to become even more meaningful in our lives. By having its interpretation subject to change, music can take on new meanings for us; it is not an untouchable relic of the past. Rather, it is alive, continually interacting with us. In this way, the memories and emotions associated with the music we listen to continue to live on as we get to keep in touch with them. Like in a relationship with a valued individual, our relationships with the music we listen to are always evolving—though we ourselves and our understanding of a song may change over time, the song is still there. A clinical study showed the difference between the young and old in how they remember music (Karin Bijsterveld and José van Dijck 109). Whereas younger listeners associated music with specific autobiographical events, older participants associated music with broader memories and emotions from their past; despite having a less vivid recollection of the past, the older people generally considered the music they listened to in a more nostalgic mood (Karin Bijsterveld and José van Dijck 110). In this way, even with a less firm grasp of the past, the older listeners had deeper relationships with their specified songs.

Thus, music helps us keep in touch with our past through its unchanging nature. Its strong connection with emotion and memory allows us to revisit the past vividly. Though this link to the past is ultimately subject to change like the other mechanisms of recalling the past, because the notes in the songs we listen to are the same as they were in the past, we can continue to add to our memories from the past by continually engaging with the same music. Music is another form of art; though the composer may create their works with certain messages and agendas in

mind, it is the listener, the receiver of the work that ultimately imparts meaning to it. Though we typically envision that performers are the only active participants in music, listening to music is not a passive experience. Rather, our consumption of music is an active process of understanding the music in relation to our lives. Because our engagement with music is a conscious decision, the specific music we listen to is part of our identities. In their same study, Hays and Minichiello found that the participants used music as a way to define their understanding of themselves and their identities; their engagement with music was used as a way to express themselves (440). Just as looking at photos through a photo book, we can listen to certain songs to elicit particular emotions and memories. In this way, our musical identities are integral to our identities more generally. Our struggle against time is universal; so is our relationship with music. Amidst all the vast changes in our lives, music can serve as a constant, a way to find solace, a companion with whom we confide to stay in touch with the past.

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